Meeple Melee

2 players, 10-20 minutes, ages 8+

Summary

Meeple Melee is a head-to-head, dice-rolling combat game — with a twist. This game is not played with traditional dice but instead by rolling meeples.

Each meeple can land in one of three orientations:

Sweep	**Kick**	**Punch**

Meeples act like weighted-dice. Meeples will land in **Sweep** about 1/2 of the time, **Kick** about 1/3 of the time, and **Punch** the remaining 1/6 of the time.

These probabilities work well in *Meeple Melee* as the goal is to reveal a set of meeples where you have at least 3 more **Sweep** than your opponent, 2 more **Kick** than your opponent, or 1 more **Punch** than your opponent. Each orientation is checked individually, in that order, so they have a non-transitive relationship similar to rock-paper-scissors. Players can perform actions after rolling, and the number of available actions changes throughout the game to balance luck and skill.

Components

- 16 meeples, 8 in each of 2 colors **(not included)**
- 2 small screens (3.5”x5” folded)
- 2 mini-boards (3.5x”5”)

Note: It’s important that standard meeples are used, which roll with approximately the probabilities listed above. The following meeples are known to work:

- Carcassonne
- MeepleSource.com: standard 16mm or 12mm meeples

Meeples from thegamecrafter.com do not work, unfortunately.

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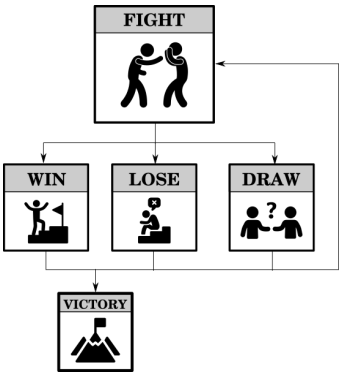
Gameplay

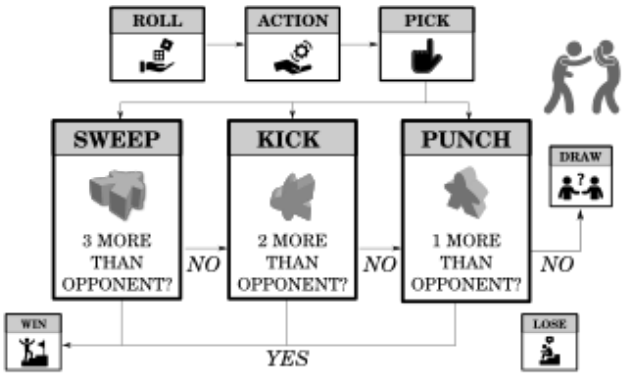
The game takes place over multiple rounds, each representing a single battle. Winning a battle captures one of your opponent's meeples, and 6 wins secures the overall victory.



A battle involves rolling all of your remaining meeples behind a screen, taking one or more actions to influence their orientation, and then picking up all but a specific number of them. When both players are ready, remove the screens and count the meeples in each orientation to see who won.

If you lose a battle, place one of your meeples on the Casualty Track. This will reduce the number of meeples you are able to roll during subsequent battles, but will also reduce the number of meeples that you and your opponent need to choose. Both players always choose the same number of meeples, so being behind is not a significant disadvantage. However, the strategy for both players needs to change as the meeple count drops. Losing a meeple may also grant you an additional action as a catch-up mechanism. In a player's final round they roll 3 meeples and have 3 actions, and therefore luck is no longer a factor.

When a battle results in a tie, both players place one of their meeples to the Neutral Zone, which raises the stakes for future battles. If you win with meeples on the Neutral Zone, you get to rescue them. If you lose, all meeples in the Neutral Zone move to the Casualty Track as if lost in battle.



ROLL	Both players roll their remaining meeples.
ACTION	Players take up to 2 of the following actions: a) reroll any number of meeples b) re-position 1 meeple by hand
PICK	Players pick up all but 1 meeples.
WIN	The winner picks up all of their meeples from the Neutral Zone (if any).
LOSE	The loser places 1 meeple on the Casualty Track (along with any in the Neutral Zone).
DRAW	Both players place 1 meeple in the Neutral Zone.

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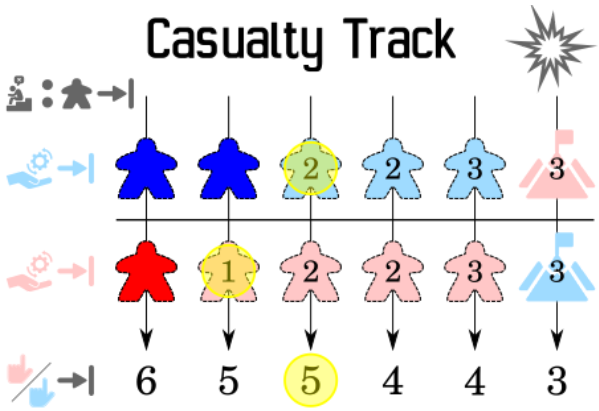
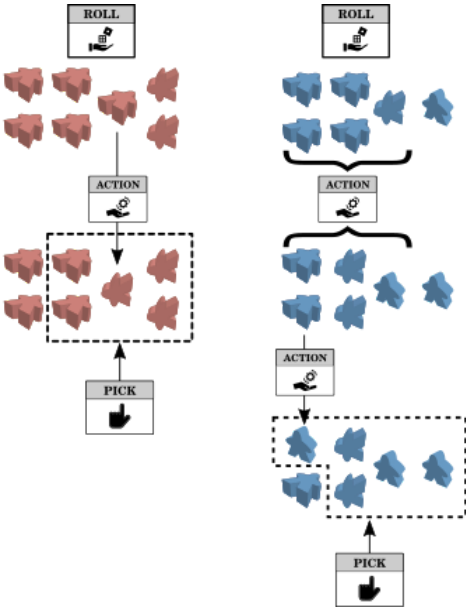
Sample Battle

This is the third battle between red and blue. The blue player won the first battle and the red player won the next two. The Casualty Track currently looks like this:



Both players begin by rolling all of their remaining meeples — 6 for blue and 7 for red. After the initial roll, blue is allowed to take 2 actions and red is still allowed only 1 action, as indicated by the highlighted areas above. After taking their actions, both players will choose 5 of their meeples.

Both players roll as indicated in this figure.



Red player uses their one action to change a Sweep to a Kick and then chooses 2 Sweep and 3 Kick.

Blue uses their first action to reroll all meeples except for their one Punch. They use their second action to change a Sweep into another Punch. They choose their 3 Punch and 2 Kicks.

Both players now reveal their choices:

- Does either have 3 more Sweep? No (2 vs. 0).
- Does either have 2 more Kick? No (3 vs. 2).
- Does either have 1 more Punch? Yes (0 vs. 3).
    - **Blue wins!**

Red now places another meeple on the Casualty Track. In the next battle, both players may now use up to 2 actions but still pick 5 meeples.

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